

A TALE OF CONTRASTS BETWEEN RIVALS

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The fans of Mohun Bagan Super Giant and East Bengal FC have different reasons to celebrate their teams' successes this time. For two of the greatest rivals in Indian football, international assignments have unfolded in contrasting ways.

While East Bengal showed great form in reaching the quarterfinals of the AFC Challenge League, Mohun Bagan narrowly avoided heavy sanctions for refusing to play its AFC Champions League Two (ACL 2) match against Tractor FC of Iran.

As it stands, East Bengal will be looking to refurbish its image in the international arena, while Mohun Bagan will have to focus on its domestic fixtures, as the team has been excluded from ACL 2 for the ongoing season.

Mohun Bagan, the reigning Indian Super League champion, appeared to place the ACL 2 low on its list of priorities as it focused on team formation specifically aimed at the ISL requirements at the start of the season. India's top league still allows four foreigners on the field, with six permitted in the squad. However, with the AFC removing the cap on registering foreign players, teams participating in the ACL must make particular arrangements during the transfer season.

Mohun Bagan SG seemed to be caught in a bind about its international plans and appeared to prioritise its resources on defending its ISL title rather than committing funds to acquire expensive foreign players. The club makes one of the largest investments among ISL teams in preparing its squad for the

season, yet when it comes to continental competitions, it seems vastly inadequate compared to teams from West Asia, which are far ahead in spending. The dependence on foreigners is greater for Indian clubs, as domestic players have yet to reach the standards required to compete with teams from that region.

Many suggest that the unrest in Iran, exacerbated by its conflict with Israel, worked in Mohun Bagan's

Setting the agenda: Mohun Bagan Super Giant, the reigning ISL champion, appeared to place the AFC Champions League Two low on its list of priorities as it focused on team formation specifically aimed at the ISL requirements at the start of the season. FSDL

